

THE GREAT

RAIL SHIFT

Convergence between Legacy Infrastructure
and Stablecoin Rails

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INTRODUCTION

Institutional data sources reflect that stablecoin settlement is nascent relative to the size of total global payment flows. Compared to the estimated more than \$1 quadrillion in cross-border payments transacted annually, stablecoins represent roughly \$33 trillion in gross transaction volume, the vast majority of which are from automated payments and trading activities. As such, while growth in stablecoin payment volumes and momentum surrounding partnerships are significant, the use of blockchain-enabled infrastructure for cross-border payments remains in its early stages.

There are robust benefits to the legacy financial infrastructure. Most notably, these include network effects between partnering institutions, regulatory clarity, counterparty trust, privacy, security, revocability, transaction-level sanctions screening, and deep liquidity. Nonetheless, correspondent banking relationships have eroded in recent times, and subsequent systemic payment friction has pushed multinational enterprises, fintechs, and banks, particularly in emerging markets, to seek solutions.

There have thus emerged opportunities for enterprises to leverage stablecoins for large-value, cross-border transactions, as we will outline here. As a white-label payment solution for banks, fintechs, and multinationals, Delos clears and settles fiat and digital currencies within a consistent, regulated venue - enabling use cases in cross-border FX, treasury management, and import-export.

Through our research, it is evident that, rather than replacing legacy infrastructure, blockchains will integrate into the existing web, forming a layered hybrid architecture. This is the future that Delos seeks to enable.

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...the hard part is clearing in a compliant, risk-friendly manner — against regulated fiat accounts, in the same venue, with FX and custody built in... We run stablecoins as native rails inside a bank-grade compliance spine, including our own Instant Internal Settlement Network. That’s the difference between a bridge and a clearinghouse.”



JACK LUTTRELL
Chief Commercial Officer,
Delos Financial

PART ONE

THE



**CURRENT
LANDSCAPE**

IMF estimates suggest that SWIFT-based cross-border payments account for the vast majority of global traditional cross-border flows, with wholesale uses such as liquidity management, FX, securities settlement and interbank payments dominating overall volume. Eighty percent of global SWIFT flows are estimated to stem from wholesale payments, with B2B, retail, etc., comprising the remaining categories.

The existing infrastructure is remarkably robust. Fedwire Funds, the Federal Reserve's high-value RTGS system used by banks, businesses and government agencies for mission-critical, same-day payments, routinely processes \$3–5T daily. CHIPS, the largest private-sector USD clearing and settlement system, clears and settles just over \$2T in domestic and international payments per business day. And FedNow, the Federal Reserve's instant payment service for retail and business transactions, is now settling \$2.7–3B per day, based on 2025 - Q1 2026 data.

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At this point, moving money is a solved problem. You know, everyone can do that, be that in traditional finance or now in the stablecoin space. But what nobody has really cracked yet, from my perspective, is letting enterprise configure the rules about how they move money.”



JORDAN MATTHEWS
Product, MoonPay

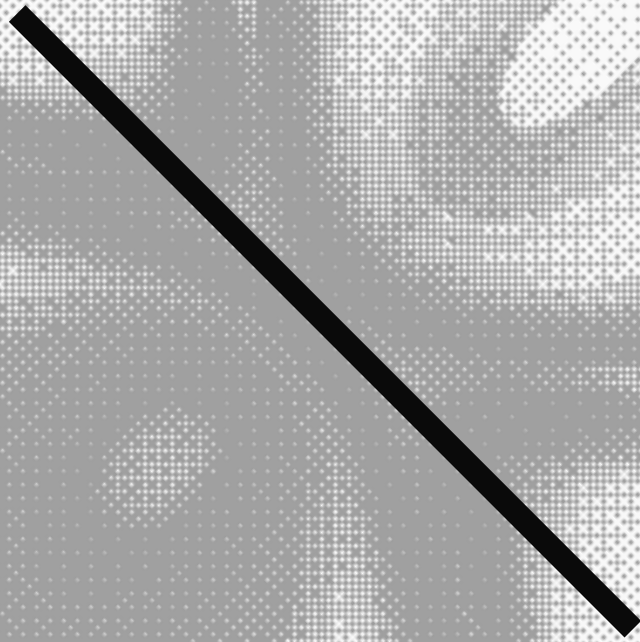
The SWIFT messaging system transports instructions between correspondent banks, which subsequently settle between their own balance sheets. Delays in cross-border transactions, often due to weak banking relationships or internal compliance, contribute to the narrative that SWIFT is slow. In high-volume corridors, SWIFT ‘moves’ rapidly.

However, while SWIFT is effective as a messaging system, the limits of the underlying infrastructure introduce cost inefficiencies. \$5T+ remains siloed in nostro-vostro accounts in order to guarantee payment execution. The opportunity cost of this siloed liquidity (e.g. foregone yield), as well as the costs of treasury operations and FX hedging to manage that capital, all contribute to substantial untold costs.

To date, stablecoins have started to make a notable impact in amending the limitations of legacy infrastructure. While estimates of organic stablecoin volumes differ (\$35T being oft-cited), segmenting by use case reveals trading and ‘non-payment activity’ (such as liquidity provisioning and internal rebalancing) comprises 99% of stablecoin volumes. Of the stablecoin volumes originating from organic payment activity (the subject of this report), B2B payments are the leading use case, representing roughly 60%.

PART TWO

STABLECOIN ADOPTION



TODAY

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People will only store and hold stablecoins to the extent that they can actually use them in at least a way that it's better than with fiat.”



RODRI FERNÁNDEZ TOUZA
CEO, Crossmint

A readily-apparent advantage for stablecoins has been their ability to move freely between jurisdictions (or rather to be ‘non-jurisdictional’) as well as enabling atomic settlement. Today, there are effectively three major flows of funds for cross-border B2B payments. The most prominent, traditional FX, requires a bank’s capital markets team to facilitate an order for a source currency to a destination currency. That bank, by virtue of being connected to the SWIFT network and to global liquidity pools, facilitates that transaction fiat-to-fiat; settlement can typically take ‘T+1’ or ‘T+2,’ depending on the corridor.

However, other ways unlocked by stablecoins can be cheaper and faster than this method. To use the example of executing a payment in Brazilian real to a recipient in South Korea, a market maker may mint a Brazilian real stablecoin and initiate a transaction between a Brazilian real stablecoin and a Korean won stablecoin before redeeming Korean won locally. This stablecoin-to-stablecoin transaction is known as onchain FX. Alternatively, a local OTC desk or liquidity provider may swap Brazilian real against USDC and then redeem USDC against Korean won.

To date, much of the best pricing and execution for transactions involving stablecoins takes place in centralized order books by liquidity providers with low cost of capital, deep liquidity, and relationships with stablecoin issuers. While centralized venues come with various efficiencies, both centralized and decentralized venues are integral to the growing matrix, with their respective use often being case-dependent.

Settling stablecoin transactions in one currency peg is a simple atomic transaction. However, with cross-border FX, a payment orchestration provider must guarantee an FX rate, necessitating access to deep liquidity. As such, payment orchestration providers seek to aggregate liquidity across banks, market makers, and stablecoin venues so that clients can access one pool and one set of quotes for any fiat or stablecoin pair. Among them, XFX routes orders dynamically across multiple venues and rails, using AI-optimized liquidity paths to minimize slippage and spread.

Delos, similarly, routes across a network of correspondent banks and MPC-custodied digital assets, matching the deepest available liquidity for each corridor. The goal of all stablecoin orchestration, thus, is to maximize the utilization of capital by leveraging the programmability of digital assets.

“

Issuing the token is not the same as creating the market for the token... You need to figure out distribution and you need to figure out liquidity.”



SANTI ALVARADO
CEO, XFX

Stablecoin Pricing

The competitiveness of stablecoin settlement must be evaluated on a corridor by corridor basis. Month-to-month (and day-to-day), stablecoins trade at a discount or a premium to interbank rates depending on provider depth, the volume and nature of flows, and pricing stability of the underlying currency. Incentivized by the market opportunity for new providers, increased liquidity has improved spreads, such that stablecoins consistently trade at par with interbank rates in the highest volume corridors.

Borderless.xyz, which provides stablecoin payment orchestration infrastructure, also provides aggregated, anonymized pricing data from dozens of liquidity providers. Data from millions of transactions show that in Kenya, Tanzania, and Rwanda, as an example, demonstrable pricing convergence (between 60 and 80% in Q1'26) occurred due to an increase in provider depth.

This is a uniform trend across corridors; an increase in provider depth leads to a compression in the stablecoin premium (or discount). Latin America, for example, exhibited a stablecoin premium within 22 bps of interbank rates for all of Q1 '26, due to a competitive marketplace for order flow. The stablecoin FX market in Latin America is effectively institutional-grade, reflected in near-parity pricing with interbank rates, competitive provider depth, and predictable execution costs.

In Q2 '26, the median stablecoin premium globally was -3.2 bps. This means, day-matched against the same day's interbank rate across 57 currencies, stablecoin delivery fell below parity with traditional FX. In simple terms, stablecoins were cheaper. This discount stems from bypassing the margins and fees added on top of the interbank rate (the rate banks trade with each other) as well as pricing convergence due to provider depth. Looking forward, value accrual within payment orchestration, as margins compress, will be derived from competitive settlement speed, breadth of coverage, and provider redundancy that prevents persistent price dislocation.

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You're going to have more volume moving onto stablecoin rails. That extra volume is going to make pricing more competitive compared to legacy rails. That more competitive pricing brings more volume, that increased volume makes pricing even more competitive, et cetera.”



KEVIN LEHTINIITTY
CEO, Borderless

“

Having the ability to go from your local currency to a USD-denominated stablecoin and settle with one of your suppliers across the world instantaneously is immensely valuable.”



ANDRE MASSE
COO, CONDUIT

In corridors where stablecoins trade at a premium, the benefit can still be reflected in cost savings elsewhere in the supply chain. In import-export use cases, since cargo held in ports incurs demurrage and storage costs, atomic settlement using stablecoins reduces FX risk by enabling immediate currency conversion and saving on costs stemming from delays and FX hedging. As mentioned previously, since pre-funding nostro-vostro accounts in multiple corridors also creates significant capital inefficiencies for enterprises, stablecoins and local off-ramps enable enterprises to more flexibly top-up these accounts, even if they incur an FX premium.

Today, Delos has experienced the highest volume for use cases pertaining to B2B supplier settlement and treasury movement, such as payables, capital calls, drawdowns and distributions across jurisdictions. Meanwhile, the fastest growing use case has been providing embedded, regulated fiat rails for fintech and web3 companies, commodity traders, and traditional finance, which use Delos as an on/off-ramp to speed settlement and unlock trapped capital. These high-value stablecoin transactions require onchain liquidity depth and efficient FX conversion on both ends. The adoption flywheel for stablecoins, by which increased volumes produce more competitive pricing, is expected to accelerate as stablecoins continue to trade at interbank parity, attracting stablecoin and non-stablecoin-native companies as end users.

Treasury Management & Cross-Border Trade

Fireblocks, which orchestrated \$5.9T in stablecoin volume in 2025, notes that enterprise adoption has concentrated on business payouts and corporate treasury. While global enterprises already enjoy favorable relationships with large banks (that provide preferential FX rates and innovative ways to hedge FX and earn yield on escrowed cash), mid-sized multinationals lack the negotiating power of a truly global company but retain much of the same operating complexity. This results in higher costs on a relative basis, stemming from slower settlement cycles and weaker access to liquidity and credit than their competitors.

In the import-export use case, where T+3 to T+5 settlement windows are the norm for emerging markets, near-instant settlement with stablecoins enables an improvement in FX hedging and liquidity management that was previously infeasible.

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You're essentially sourcing that liquidity in an open way across the entire economy of people that are utilizing this currency, and so your ability to fulfill these transactions is just significantly higher on stablecoins than it is through one bank.”



CHRIS MAURICE
CEO, Yellow Card

In cross-border trade, a spread on the FX conversion is applied from the sending and receiving banks, causing the total costs of conversion to climb to 2-7% per transaction on average. These costs, which include wire fees, undisclosed FX markups, and the costs of failed or returned payments, compound as companies scale. Additionally, the opportunity cost of siloed liquidity and the impact of settlement delays on delivery times, contract negotiations, and inventory management remain hidden costs.

By bypassing the correspondent banking FX stack and enabling importers to invoice, hold, and settle entirely within a dollar-denominated ecosystem, stablecoins improve the cost, risk, and velocity of money movement within an FX transaction. Further, the FX conversion that does take place occurs more reliably, as aggregated liquidity for stablecoin pairs enables more accurate pricing. For businesses in markets with chronic currency volatility, this improvement in FX risk management preserves margins.

In addition, stablecoins unlock previously inaccessible corridors. Triple-A, which facilitates payments by receiving USD stablecoins from importers, holding fiat obligations on its own balance sheet, and settling in the respective fiat currency, provides better FX rates for importers, frees up working capital, and enables exporters to access more markets. Access to dollar-denominated settlement without a USD banking relationship is the biggest unlock for companies operating in emerging markets.

As highlighted by ARP Digital, a digital asset infrastructure firm building institutional stablecoin and payment rails across the GCC and emerging markets, the settlement leg of a physical commodity trade, rather than logistics or trade finance, is where most of the friction lies. Settlement costs include letters of credit issuance and confirmation fees, correspondent banking charges, compliance overhead, and FX spreads (applied by the destination correspondent bank ex post facto). In the GCC, where commodity trade between South Asia, Central Asia, and Africa has expanded while correspondent banking friction stiffens, traders experience additional overhead from extra compliance screening from Dubai's commodities exchange and free-trade zone, DMCC, as free zone entities exhibit ownership structures that are harder to verify. As such, converting AED, BHD, or other local currencies into regulated stablecoins bypasses the "correspondent hop," while fixing the exchange rate at origination.

In sub-Saharan Africa, where there is a \$400B credit shortage, \$140B of that is represented by trade financing. Due to local currency volatility, foreign exporters demand large down payments (sometimes 60% or more) denominated in USD. However, importers are subject to waitlists, capital controls, and lengthy underwriting from banks to access USD - and even then often only in limited quantities for approved industries. This need for dollar liquidity prompted Keyrails to use its own attested SWIFT transaction data to audit importers against prior trading activity and issue short term credit in USD stablecoins to pay exporters. Such injection of dollar liquidity lowers the cost of capital, accelerates trade, and circumvents the counterparty risks of alternative credit systems.

Still, a more common use case is cash collection from capital-restrictive markets. Where corporate treasuries cannot repatriate or deploy local currency balances, companies such as Yellow Card and VelaFi turn local-currency balances into USD-linked stablecoin liquidity and provide regulated rails to move that value across borders. Across use cases, a differentiating capability of stablecoin rails is programmability. Beyond settlement efficiency, this enables access to DeFi-native yield.

Yield Opportunities

To make settlement more efficient, the goal of stablecoin cross-border payments is to compress the settlement cycle and to insert the optionality of yield in the settlement process. This includes seamless access to yield-bearing assets, such as tokenized sovereign debt and yield-bearing stablecoins, as well as the ability to borrow against onchain collateral. Similar products already exist for the largest corporate treasuries; the value of stablecoins, thus, is democratization.

While the market for tokenized Treasuries remains in its infancy (\$15.5B by recent estimates), even a small migration of stablecoin liquidity into tokenized T-bills would materially impact depth of onchain funding markets. As such, interoperable, auditable blockchains unlock payment, treasury management, and lending opportunities that were previously unviable.

The sources of onchain yield have also matured. By enabling professional yield management onchain, Morpho has positioned itself as the onchain lending protocol of choice for DeFi and non-DeFi native asset managers, providing permissionless access to an institutional-grade yield source. Meanwhile, marketplaces such as Maple provide yield from an actively-managed tokenized loan book through a yield-bearing stablecoin. Regardless of the method, accessing institutional-grade yield sources remains a macro tailwind for stablecoin adoption.

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Traditional payment companies are monopolizing distinct industries, and I think stablecoins will probably go the similar route. Right now, I think we're in Stablecoin 2.0. The next stage, Stablecoin 3.0, is not just payments, it's integration into applications... combining DeFi APYs with strong risk controls, short-term lending products... I think that's where stablecoins have a lot more flexibilities, a lot more opportunities.”



MAGGIE WU
CEO, VelaFi

Geographic Concentration, Dollarization, & Parallel Markets

From the highest-volume corridors, such as US-Mexico, to emerging volumes between Asia and Latin America, the readiness of counterparties to adopt stablecoin rails reflects the utility and product-market fit of stablecoins globally.

Asia accounts for roughly 60% of global stablecoin payment volumes, driven largely by B2B transactions originating from Hong Kong, Singapore, and Japan. The Singapore-to-China corridor, cited among the most active, is primarily used for trade and B2B payments. US/HK/SG-to-SE Asia, the dominant aggregate corridor, is led by B2B payments, ecommerce, and payroll, corresponding to the transition to primary payroll infrastructure for stablecoin payouts in the global freelance and contractor economy.

The Asia-Latam payment corridor has also grown remarkably, particularly due to nearshoring, as well as Asian exporters accessing Latin American consumers. Further, the China-LATAM and China-Africa trade corridors represent structurally attractive stablecoin adoption candidates due to entrenched trade relationships alongside correspondent banking friction. In Africa in particular, new liquidity provider interest has been incentivized by an opportunity to capture larger market share while earning higher spreads.

A ripple effect of the adoption of dollar stablecoins is diminished demand for local currencies. Increasingly weak demand for exotic currencies, particularly those which suffer most from volatility and inflation, may cause central banks to implement forms of taxation, capital controls or forced conversions in order to retain monetary sovereignty.

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Cross border payments translate directly to economic growth...If you're able to remove friction barriers, it's going to have like multiplier effects. And that's where payments are very critical to the economy.”

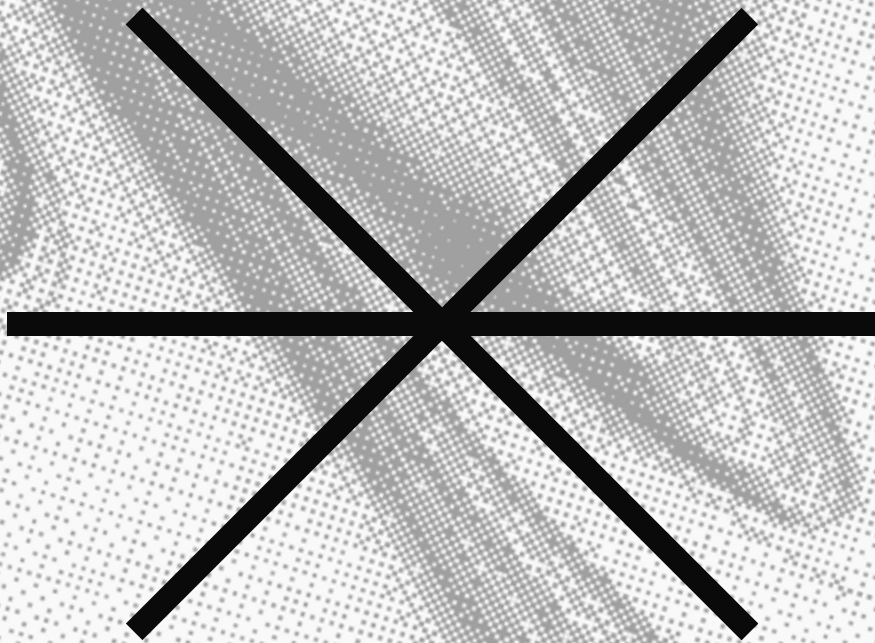


BASSAM ELSHORAF
Head of Partnerships, ARP Digital

While stablecoins themselves don't create new parallel markets (i.e. official and unofficial exchange rates), they do highlight the differences. Rather than exacerbating the spread, with the introduction of new liquidity providers, the spreads between the official and unofficial rates will more readily converge in multiple corridors. However, in corridors where stablecoins persistently trade at steep premiums (e.g. hundreds or thousands of bps), the premium is often more indicative of the 'real rate' than the country's official exchange rate.

PART THREE

PATH



**TO
CONVERGENCE**

Growth estimates for stablecoin issuance and volume remain promising. Citi Institute cites a \$1.9T base case for 2030 stablecoin issuance (coupled with \$100T in annual volume). Keyrock and Bitso's research forecasts that stablecoins will comprise 12% of global cross-border payment volume by the same year.

Presently, stablecoin growth remains driven by the crypto-native ecosystem, trading, and international demand for holding USD, with stablecoin-linked cards being an effective distribution mechanism for financial access in emerging markets. In addition to B2B flows, the convergence between stablecoin rails and fiat is expected to include retail participation (in the form of stablecoin cards, agentic commerce, etc.) and a robust coordination layer of stablecoin infrastructure, fintechs, and banks.

The Role of Banks and Clearinghouses

Citibank projects that bank-issued tokenized deposits may surpass stablecoins in transaction volume due to their ability to capture wholesale institutional payments. Tokenized deposits offer the programmability and execution of stablecoins, but with an enhanced level of trust (as they are issued by regulated commercial banks and are backed by commercial bank deposits). Meanwhile, the risk profile of stablecoins depends on the issuer's regulation and reserve quality, which can vary. While fragmentation across issuers and chains may persist, the key is interoperability between these systems, chains, and tokens.

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I believe in the end of the day that banks will have stablecoins behind the scenes, but the user will still see it in many cases just as a US dollar, just as a Euro.



BENTZI RABI
CEO, Utila

To unify the benefits of fiat and stablecoins into a single infrastructure, a clearing mechanism is essential. A form of stablecoin clearing that guarantees conversion between stablecoins of the same currency peg would enable ‘singleness of money.’ The Better Money Company, a clearing layer for stablecoins, is one such experiment, enabling any stablecoin to be exchanged at par. Settling directly to banks also theoretically strengthens the counterparty network for stablecoins as a whole. Systemically-important financial institutions (SIFIs) can custody funds of stablecoin issuers, strengthening their own balance sheets, and provide issuers with reduced counterparty risk.

The interdependence of the largest banks for wholesale flows means that a token issued by one such bank (e.g. JPMorgan Chase’s JPMD, a deposit token) would be operationally equivalent to holding USD, since that bank is a trusted counterparty for other SIFIs as well as regional banks. The participation of major banks as a clearing layer also theoretically enables one-to-one liquidity across stablecoins, making onchain and ‘off-chain’ money fully interoperable.

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As long as fiat and stablecoins, and now deposit tokens, live together, there needs to be centralization. You can't escape that.”



BERHAN KONGEL
CEO, Keyrails

However, the direct involvement of banks is not a foregone conclusion. Regulatory breakthroughs, such as the GENIUS Act, that create guidelines for bank participation in stablecoin issuance, also limit the scalability of these activities. From a cost perspective, banks holding stablecoins on their balance sheets is an expensive endeavor, since issuers must maintain one-to-one reserve backing. Further, issuers are not permitted to offer any form of interest or yield to stablecoin holders, making stablecoins only attractive for transactional use cases, such as cross-border settlement, and not a compelling alternative to bank deposits or money market funds. Stablecoin issuers also cannot lend against reserves, limiting the profitability of issuance as a whole. For non-bank financial institutions, however, the GENIUS Act is a boon. A digital asset exchange or neobank, for example, could leverage customers'

deposits to issue a USD stablecoin and generate yield from the underlying collateral.

Industry practitioners, thus, theorize that tokenized deposits (which are not subject to one-to-one reserve backing), may be able to fill in the gaps. While they do not differ greatly from what the correspondent banking model currently enables, tokenized deposits introduce more interoperability between fragmented payment structures, thus making interbank settlement more efficient overall. The launch of SWIFT Ledger is a prime indicator of this possible hybrid future. The blockchain-based settlement network, developed in conjunction with more than 40 banks, integrates with Chainlink's CCIP to connect the SWIFT network's 11,000+ institutions to blockchain settlement.

Concerns about stablecoins absorbing deposits from local banks and subsequent constricted credit origination are further solved with tokenized deposits. Tokenized deposits remain on a bank's balance sheet, enabling 'digital dollars' to remain in the fractional-reserve banking system, while preserving the velocity of money empowered by blockchains. They also diversify collateral away from short-dated Treasuries, reducing the concentration risk of the current model. As tokenized deposits do not qualify as payment stablecoins, banks can operate a dual strategy of issuing and utilizing stablecoins for domestic and cross-border payments and tokenized deposits for wholesale interbank settlement and credit.

For Delos, banks are the regulated backbone stablecoins settle against. As the company expects tokenized deposits and bank tokens to win regulated, high-value institutional flows, it remains rail - and issuer - agnostic.

Distribution Moats

The emergence of bank/consortia-issued stablecoins has revealed latent competitive dynamics within stablecoin infrastructure. Recently-announced Open USD (OUSD), for example, seeks to distribute reserve interest income with its consortium partners, which span payment networks and processors, asset managers, banks, technology companies, and crypto-native firms. In contrast to Tether and Circle, this yield-sharing model is a consequential shift in incentive alignment between stablecoin issuers and the platforms that create distribution for them.

The premise behind OUSD is that, incentivized by reserve income, members of the consortium will provide liquidity for the token on their respective platforms. While this may oversimplify the tradeoffs for each consortium member, the distribution moats of USDT and USDC should also not be underestimated. Due to the depth of liquidity within trading and settlement use cases, the network effects for USDT and USDC have not been meaningfully challenged. At 60% of stablecoin supply, Tether's breadth of integrations means that platforms and protocols relying on it for liquidity face significant inertia.

Furthermore, USDT and USDC have not been meaningfully challenged by non-USD currencies due to structural demand for USD. As approval for HKD stablecoins exemplifies, non-USD stablecoin growth is contingent on regional use cases. A HKD stablecoin, which is effectively pegged to USD, is an innovative way for Hong Kong-based businesses to access dollar-equivalent liquidity for institutional cross-border payments and onchain settlement through a locally-regulated instrument.

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The direction of travel is multi-currency, even if the center of gravity stays USD for a while...Moats erode when regulated bank tokens and credible non-USD issuers arrive with real distribution.”



JACK LUTTRELL
Chief Commercial Officer,
Delos Financial

To date, non-USD stablecoins have experienced the most adoption in geographies where real-time payment networks (such as SPEI in Mexico, Pix in Brazil, and UPI in India) are not available and where the local payment rails are unreliable, presenting a mechanism to more seamlessly interface with the local economy.

Across geographies, multinational enterprises interfacing with local currencies are expected to seek exposure to local stablecoins. This will enable enterprises operating outside of a country to settle to a local currency bank account without the operational overhead of managing a local banking relationship. Here, the benefits of stablecoin settlement are fully on display.

The commodification of stablecoin infrastructure is also less of a concern for some market participants, as providing a ubiquitous layer of liquidity is expected to create new forms of value accrual.

A possible endpoint, thus, is a hybrid architecture wherein a cluster of prominent stablecoins settle the majority of transaction volume, banks/consortiums issue stablecoins in order to have interoperability with the rest of the system, and a clearinghouse(s) brings harmony to the entire network.

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I think of stablecoins in a way where it's not just about asset or money movement... To me, it's about the use cases of stablecoins as infrastructure - as ways to be able to create value and financial services that go beyond concepts that we have today.”



DAREN GUO
CEO, Reap

Agentic Payments

High-value, B2B agentic payments require infrastructure for onchain agentic transacting as well as real-world fiat settlement. At the moment, constraints to adoption stem from compliance concerns as well as data infrastructure and privacy. Current implementations focus on sub-cent transactions between agents, such as API micropayments, where blockchains have become the de facto rails. To settle funds with fiat, however, the underlying infrastructure must incorporate a new layer that includes established governance and legal framing as well as cryptographic mechanisms for ‘guardrailing’ agentic transactions.

The “on behalf of” (OBO) framework, an emerging OAuth-derived delegation pattern being adapted for payments, whereby an AI agent executes financial transactions or payment instructions on behalf of a human principal, proposes a clear chain of delegation that is critical for AML and sanctions compliance. It is a governance and identity-propagation framework that defines how an agent carries a user’s delegated authority into downstream systems, answering the question of who the agent is acting for and with what scope.

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**Agent to agent, machine to machine,
with pre-established trust...
That’s where it can really be used.”**



ERIC BARBIER
CEO, Triple-A

Meanwhile, the ‘verifiable intent’ framework, Mastercard and Google’s jointly launched open-source specification, is an example of a cryptographic credential layer that links user identity, delegated scope, and agent action in a tamper-resistant audit trail. It is a ‘proof layer’ that makes policy frameworks such as OBO machine-enforceable. Together, they provide the legal precedent and cryptographic verifiability to enable agentic commerce at scale.

To use an analogy from card transactions, the technological breakthrough of separating auth and capture (authorization being the process that verifies that the card has sufficient funds, while capture finalizes the transaction), unlocked a variety of use cases and business models, from booking travel to purchasing petrol or using a vending machine.

As such, frameworks for “intent/eligibility” and “execution/finalization” for agentic transactions would empower deferred, conditional, and machine-driven commerce. While current regulatory considerations remain unresolved, such as the lack of clear guidance on whether an AI agent acting on behalf of a human satisfies existing AML/KYC obligations, technical progress with regard to scope creep, auditability, permission controls, and fraud have made great strides.

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Every configuration has the potential to change the regime of liability, the regime of the control...”



CHRISTOPHER GRILHAULT DES FONTAINES
CEO, DFNS

As such, it is plausible that mass adoption of agentic payments will first begin for machine-to-machine use cases, where the ‘blast radius’ is limited, before retail and enterprise use cases are considered at scale. However, a more immediate and compelling implementation for enterprises is automated, deterministic payments for which the programmability of stablecoins provides a useful technology stack. What is indisputable, thus, is the preeminence that stablecoin rails will play in this agentic future due to their programmability, interoperability, and ability to reduce overhead.

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It’s a combination of the regulatory environment, the licensing, the compliance that involves all of those different rails and dynamics, consumer education and adoption, the distribution across the middle layer. All those things sort of need to connect and align for any piece of fintech infrastructure to scale.”



DAVI STRAZZA
CBO, Lightspark

CONCLUSION

Currently, we are yet to see the final shape of the new financial system which includes the convergence of legacy infrastructure with stablecoins. While the technology to properly merge traditional financial systems with blockchains and blockchain adjacent systems is developed from a technical or regulatory perspective, the system we have today resembles the early stages of the World Wide Web - a world of a 'thousand internets' - fragmented but converging.

In the world of payments, each time a significant problem is solved with regard to size, speed or interoperability, new industries subsequently emerge. As such, liquidity drivers, such as facilitating remittance, asset tokenization, and even card issuance, all contribute to an ecosystem wherein large-scale B2B enterprise stablecoin transactions become more possible.

Clear momentum for treasury management, trade finance, and import-export use cases foreshadow a future wherein blockchain-based systems unlock new possibilities. Still, compliance, regulation, and integration into accounting and ERP systems remain critical impediments. Eventually, the next frontier of innovation will yield horizontally-embedded infrastructure underpinning payment services of all kinds.

It's worth emphasizing the extent to which cross border payments translate directly to economic growth; removing barriers to economic activity yields powerful multiplier effects in favour of economic empowerment. The future Delos is building towards is one in which stablecoins function as an intermediate settlement layer that connects compliant bank endpoints, and subsequently unlocks economic opportunity for more people globally.

